

Unit 11

Group Behaviour – 1 (Introduction to Group Behaviour)

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11.1 Introduction

In the previous unit you learnt individual level behavioural variables. You also learnt learning and applications. This unit is dedicated to learning the group decision process. In order to understand the process, we cover the related areas. The unit will give a clear understanding of the process so that when you have to work in a group, take decision and execute tasks you can do those effectively.

Over the years, groups have become the norm in many organisations. This is because the complexity of business grew exponentially over the years and it became no more possible for one person to consider all factors and take a decision. The volume of information available and the expertise required in understanding the information made groups imperative. However, group decision making and use of groups for execution is useful only if the group process in decision making is handled systematically. If not, groups can and often take far inferior decisions than an individual does because of various reasons.

Objectives:

- To define Group and understand the concept of a Group.
- To gain insight into the Group Process.
- To understand how a group behaves.
- To appreciate group behavior and its implications to decision making organizational effectiveness.

Outcomes:

After studying this unit, you will be able to:

- define group.
- explain the concept of a Group.
- identify group process and explain its implications on the group decisions.
- explain the Work Group Behavior model
- determine the factors that affect Group Behavior
- list the implications of Group Process on organizations.

11.2 Case Study

'URShop' abbreviated by all as URS was started in 1970 with its headquarters in Hyderabad. It was in the business of home electronics. Riding the Indian TV wave, URS set up shop in most Indian cities and often more than one outlet in the metros. Over a period of time, URS expanded on an all India basis. URS was known for its quality customer service and when the Japanese and Korean companies came to India, they quickly embraced them as a preferred outlet. URS service was unbeatable. URS was always a place for individual excellence and high individual incentives. With the advent of the Japanese electronics giants and expansion, the top management laid out a plan to en-culture the group in the DNA of URS. They knew that it was the way forward.

A typical URS shop was large, about 15 to 20 thousand square feet with the domestic electronics in neat groups. The groups were home entertainment which covered TV and music system with its related accessories, kitchen group which had all kitchen equipment from fridges to smoke extractors, home use which had other electronic items like water heater, iron, fans, coolers, air conditioners, a computer group

which catered for PCs and later laptops, an electronics furniture group which stocked furniture related to these electronic equipment.

A General Manager (GM) headed each outlet with a Manager (Sales) and Assistant Manager (Installation and Service) for each group. Each group had 7 to 10 members.

Each outlet had a command group with the GM as its head and the managers as the members. There was a strategic steering committee and a Customer Relations Standing committee which were cross functional groups of the Assistant Managers under the Manager, home entertainment group, which typically had the highest sales and the highest call for installation and service support. A third cross functional group was the quality group which monitored every quality issue be it service, the suppliers, the installation and so on. The groups led the business. Each outlet was audited once a year by a national cross functional group which would come and spend three days in the shop watching the sales process. The National Cross functional team also had a mystery shopping function when disguised as customers, they would shop in another outlet. They awarded the best outlet and during the visit they had elaborate discussions with the employees and managers and shared several experiences which they gained during the visit. The groups were incentivized and they had a major say in accepting a new member i.e., a new employee and they had to be accountable to increase the sales. The groups could also take a decision to drop a supplier if they wished to. The groups usually had a jam session every two months. These were sessions where they critiqued their own work. The atmosphere would be tense and no one spared anyone except that they had a strong norm that no one would throw a personal comment and if they did, the person would sit with a hat for the rest of the meeting. Those who did not contribute significantly for two consecutive jam sessions would normally stand everyone a dinner and if you missed it a third time, the group considered sacking the member and replacing him. There were plenty of cases of throwing dinner but only one of being sacked in the last five years.

URS had an open door policy. Anyone could see the compensation package and incentive of anyone else and though the HR department

was very big to cater for this detailed information support, the top management did not mind. They rule. Let them know the results they have produced. If the revenue of a group fell, the members had the right to seek intervention and sack the Manager if they felt that he was an impediment. Similarly, the group could sack a member for not contributing effectively to the revenue. The system of sales monitoring clearly indicated the sales achieved by each member of the group and therefore the sacking could be done scientifically. Of course, the individual had to be given two warnings before the sacking which the group did collectively in the monthly group meeting.

After five years when the top management took stock of the situation through financial analysis and elaborate interviews done using consultants, they found that the system has increased the revenue by 1200 percent. After discounting for national growth the growth was still some 250 percent. There were strains in group relationship. Some cliques had formed which prevented the sacking even when warranted. At least two Managers had been sacked due to group pressure. The employees in general detested the idea of wearing a cap and sitting in a meeting for non-contribution. Some highly individualistic but excellent installation engineers had found the system strange as they were slogging it out in customer houses and these air-condition loving employees were sitting on their fate.

The question that bothered the top management was not whether group concept is required or not but how far can we take the group concept and where should they rein that in? Have we sacrificed individual excellence for the sake of the group?

11.3 Definition and Concept of Groups

In today's world everyone speaks of group, group effect and the impact of group. People hire you for your ability to work in groups, business schools train you for it and eventually you are assessed and even rewarded for this. So, what is group?

Definition

A group is defined as two or more individuals who have regular contact and frequent interaction, mutual influence, common feeling of camaraderie and who work together to achieve a common set of goals. 'Size, interaction, influence and goal' are the key ingredients of this definition and enables us to distinguish a group from a collection of people. Group are almost always a subset of a larger organisation e.g., it can be a group in a company where the company is the superset, football group of the village where the village is the superset, dance group in school where the school is the superset, etc.

Concept of a group

A group is based on the concept of synergy to attain the goal. By synergy we mean that the sum total of the output by the individual members are collectively surpassed by the group and this happens because of its ability to create better input (ideas) and work practices that cover the deficiencies of each other. Social facilitation theory explains how performance tends to improve or decline in the presence of others. In fact the synergy is dependent on social facilitation. Social facilitation effect also results in people who are proficient in a job doing the same job faster and better in the presence of a group and those who are not proficient doing it worse in the presence of a group. Interestingly, if we have to train people on simple things, it is better to do it in a group as the learning is faster and if on complex things, it is better to train them individually. That perhaps explains why mentoring is far more effective than a class room session or group activity in training managers to take decisions.

Purpose of groups

People join groups for various reasons such as:

- **Goal achievement:** When it takes more than one person to do a thing e.g., an orchestra or play cards, or design a system, make a commentary, think and create a solution, you need to join a group.
- **Identity:** It gives people identity and therefore enhances their self esteem and often the affiliation needs.
- **Power and status:** Groups give both since a group is able to ascertain rights of its members better and give them a position in society and life.
- **Safety and security:** Groups provide both.

Concept of small groups

Although the definition states that two or more people form a group, in general, a small group is one that has at least three and no more than twelve to fifteen members. A group should usually have at least three members, else it is a dyad. The need to distinguish between a dyad and a group is important because the latter can create coalitions and can have some sort of organisation. Too large a group (more than twelve or fifteen members) inhibits the group members' ability to communicate with everyone else in the group.

Formal groups

Every organisation is divided into formal organisational structures such as marketing, finance, operations, project etc. These are often called departments and technically they have the characteristics of a group i.e., size, interaction, influence and goals. However, these characteristics are not strict (i.e., the size is large, interaction few, influence limited and goals many) in the department of an organisation. Now, if the department has to accomplish a specific goal, it would have to create a group within the department with a purpose of doing the work e.g., creating an audit group within the finance department. These may be permanent or temporary in nature. A formal group has the following characteristics:

- Defined goals, deadlines, and roles.
- Explicitly defined structure, procedural rules, and membership and norms.
- Relatively permanent or temporary (e.g. steering group or problem solving group).

Types of formal groups

Formal groups can be classified into the following:

- **Command group:** A command group consists of a manager and the employees who report to him or her and fits into the organisation's hierarchy. For example, outlet manager and the managers of bakery, snack meal, merchandise who report to him. Membership in the group arises from each employee's position on the organisational chart.
- **Task Group:** A task group is made up of employees who work together to complete a particular task or project. Here, the members do not report to the hierarchical superior but to the person who is given the task to do.

For example, URS' task group to identify the best outlet consists of members from various outlets and area and who do not report to the group leader in the normal process of business.

- **Committee:** A group of people officially delegated to perform a function, such as investigating, considering, reporting, or acting on a matter. They usually make recommendations and reports.

Informal groups

Within the overall structure of the organisation and the department, there can be several informal groups. The real distinction between formal and informal groups is not whether one has a structure or not. Formal group has its goals that are directly derived from the organisational goals whereas the goal of the informal group is not directly derived from the organisational goals.

Creation, purpose and types of informal groups

The informal groups are created in the workplace because of several reasons such as proximity, social and emotional need of bonding, common interests, and friendship. Research shows that if some of us sit and work together, the proximity creates the forces that eventually creates a group e.g., all those who travel in the company bus every day. Following types of informal groups are frequently seen in workplace:

- **Friendship group** may be based on age, gender, etc.
- **Interest group** is one where everyone has the same interest e.g., classical music.
- **A reference group** is something that comes up when one wants to use it as a source to help with decision making e.g., when one uses the above interest group for deciding on the person to be invited for a classical music evening to your son's school.
- **Membership groups** have some amount of formality. There is formal affiliation to it e.g., music clubs where often there could be some form of formal structure, membership fee, defined goals, charter etc.
- **A clique** is a relatively permanent informal group that involves intense friendship for a narrow (often negative) goal. Usually they are 5 to 12 in numbers. The members meet far more often, hang out together and support each other to an unimaginable degree, often for emotions support and at times for odd actions such as ragging, practice of some

odd religious beliefs, bad mouthing or stonewalling a management decision etc. Though cliques are not always negative, their lack of transparency and access to other people often make them dysfunctional.

Power of informal group within formal organisation

Informal groups transcend departmental boundaries. For example, the members of a friendship group or interest group may be from different departments and different hierarchies. Thus, they become the glue that connects departments. If you have members of a music group from different departments, it is easier for one of them from one department to interact with another from another department. Also, it transcends hierarchy since being members is the important aspect. Thus, it creates porosity in the formal system and makes the formal system more open.

Self Assessment Questions

1. Size, Interaction, _____ and _____ are the key ingredients of a group.
2. A group is based on the concept of _____ to attain the goal.
3. A reference group is a formal group to which disciplinary issues are referred (True/false)

11.4 Stages of Group Formation and Group Process

Stages of group formation

Conventional literature on group speaks of four or five stages in group formation. Bruce Tuckman (1965) proposed a five stage model. We will discuss this in brief and then build the concept into the group process which is more important to us because it is the process that creates synergy. The stages are:

- **Forming:** This is where the members are in the process of coming together, knowing each other, identifying the goals and in general getting over the anxiety of it all.
- **Storming:** This is a stage where members try to find out their role and expectation from others or their contribution to the goal including the obstacles. Often there is turbulence here when one perceives that the goal achievement is difficult or his abilities do not match up or is

underutilised. In formal groups, the leader can manage this stage effectively by reassuring, articulating the goals, clearing doubts etc.

- **Norming:** Here, the group comes into balance; accept a formal or informal structure, leadership, roles, duties, way of conduct etc.
- **Performing:** The group now becomes stable, knows the details and start execution. The structure is fully functional and accepted at this stage. Work proceeds as per the norms set towards the goals set. Work is monitored and control is exercised.
- **Adjourning:** Normally a group adjourns after it has accomplished its goal e.g., a project, product development etc. The process of adjourning can be personal and painful in some cases, but in formal work groups this is taken as a way of life. Some groups which are of a permanent nature do not adjourn.

The group process

Groups of individuals gathered together to achieve a goal or objective, either as a committee or some other grouping, go through several predictable stages before useful work can be done. These stages are a function of a number of variables. Self identification to each role and the emergence of natural leaders and individuals to serve as sources of information (distinguished from the formally appointed leader) are important. This process is tabulated below and thereafter explained.

Phase	Task Functions	Personal Relations Functions
1	Orientation	Testing and Dependence
2	Organizing to Get Work Done	Intragroup Conflict
3	Information-flow	Group Cohesion
4	Problem-solving	Interdependence
<i>Based on the work of Jones (1973), Tuckman (1965), and Banet (1976) and in particular the work of Jones</i>		

Phase one, two, three and four comprise the following processes which have different stages of behaviour:

- **Phase I Task:** The task here is orientation. It means we must define the task, specify its details, identify the expectations, output, and nature of the work etc. This gives the group an idea of the purpose and they see the reason for their being present there, what they are supposed to do

and how to do it and more importantly what the goals are and what is each person's role to achieve the goal.

- **Personal relations:** Personal relations are tested and dependence evaluated. In the first phase, participants generally act as if they depend on the leader to provide all the structure. They look to the leader to set the ground rules, establish the agenda, to do all the 'leading' while the group members acclimatise themselves to the setting. Feelings involved are excitement, apprehension, and confusion. Group members exhibit behaviour to test what behaviour is acceptable and what is taboo, and begin to establish boundaries, to consider themselves as individuals vis-a-vis the group, and to define the function of the group and the leader.
- **Concluding phase I:** This phase generally concludes when there is general agreement that the goals are achievable and that change is possible--whether it be changing behaviour, making a decision, or solving a problem.

Phase II

Task: The task here is to organise and get the work done. This involves a number of group decisions. These include:

- Establishing work rules
- Determining limits
- Defining the reward system
- Setting the criteria for the task
- Dividing the work
- Assigning individual responsibility for particular tasks

Personal relations: Phase II is the vital one for personal relations and can make or break a group.

- The participants bring to group activity unique perspectives and many unresolved conflicts with regard to authority, dependency, rules, and agenda. The result is that groups experience interpersonal conflict as they organise to get work done. The conflict may remain hidden, but it is there. The variety of organisational concerns that emerge reflects the interpersonal conflict over leadership and leadership structure, power, and authority. These of course emanate from the task specificity.
- Awareness of the possibility of change that was begun in Phase I becomes a denial of the possibility of and the need for change. Group

members adhere instead to one or another extreme. The feeling level is marked by dependency on old ways and resistance to take the risks involved in the decision and change. This occurs because the deep-seated values, beliefs, and world views can be challenged in this stage and though called a regression stage by some like Myers and Lamnn (1975), much work is actually accomplished.

Concluding Phase II: This phase concludes when group members have struggled enough with each other to resolve their personal relations concerns (similarities to and differences from other group members, authority, dependency, and leadership) and have agreed upon how they will organise to do the work. This allows issues to emerge that are sufficiently important for the group as a whole to consider.

Phase III

Task: Here, the task is information flow. Participants begin sharing ideas and feelings, giving and soliciting feedback, exploring actions, and sharing information related to the task. This is a period during which people become gradually more comfortable about being part of a group. There is an emerging openness with regard to the task and the group members show willingness to discuss these.

Personal relations: In Phase II, the group achieves group cohesion. In this stage, participants, having resolved interpersonal conflict, begin to experience catharsis and a feeling of belonging to a group. This enables the group to focus on the task. Different points of view enrich the group process. The members shift from 'either/ or' attitude to 'both' attitude. Members perceive that power is residing in both the group and the members. It is the central period of group development. It is common to see a brief abandonment of the task and a period of play and an enjoyment of the cohesion being experienced. There is general feeling of contentment.

Concluding Phase III: This phase ends when there is realisation that new insights have been gained and new solutions to problems are possible.

Phase IV

Task: Phase IV is based on problem solving. During this phase, the group's tasks are well-defined, there is a commitment to common activity, and there is support for experimentation in solving problems and hence the group achieves its task.

Personal relations: People feel a high degree of interdependence which is characterised by interdependence in personal relations. This means that the members can work singly in any subgroups or as a total unit. The activities are collaborative and functionally competitive. The feelings are focused on enjoyment of the here and the now. A reflective, meditative silence coexists with playful and pleasurable interaction with others. The task seems completed and there is a need for closure, repose, and quiet. This movement is marked by integration and celebration. Much work is accomplished; previously difficult issues are simply and easily resolved. There may be attempts by some members of the group to 'freeze' change and the group may decide to stop its work here, which is usually the case.

Concluding Phase IV: This phase often develops the awareness for a new beginning. The group may begin at this new starting point and work through each of the four phases in a somewhat different fashion.

Organisational support for group process

- **Phase I:** This corresponds to the forming stage. In formal groups, there would usually be a leader and the selection of the leader keeping in view of his/her style and competencies becomes very important. Those with higher competencies in establishing focus, building teamwork, and those with a democratic style of functioning with a high self esteem enable this process. It also makes sure that this process is completed quickly and sets the stage for the second and the more important phase. Some organisations plan to have this in an informal atmosphere in a hotel or resort so that this paves the way for the second phase. They create a situation that some of the elements of Phase III are created right there through informal dialogue, sharing, and trust building, thus making the Phase II more smooth.
- **Phase II:** Depending on Phase I, the organisation can enable in managing Phase II. This phase requires extensive data support which if forthcoming from the organisation, helps immensely. Also, if the organisation ensures that at least 20 to 30percent of the participants are those who have already worked in a group and created excellent rapport (assuming that the organisation keeps a database on it), the process can be speeded up. Creating cross functional groups with competencies that do not overlap is perhaps another contribution the organisation can make to ensure that the phase is smooth. If competencies are mutually

exclusive and collectively exhaustive, then the group will feel confident to take all the decisions and yet have little clash. This is not to say that there will be no conflict. It is also preferable to create an informal atmosphere and have frequent but well paced out meetings so that tempers can be cooled and people can be more objective. The leader can also manage this better if he/she takes up lesser number of issues rather than take up all issues at once and intelligently accepting and postponing those with more conflict potential.

- **Phase III:** Here, the organisation should continue to provide information support. The phase tends to move smoothly without much effort.
- **Phase IV:** This forms the basis for future group creation.

Punctuated Equilibrium Model

This is another model of group process. What this model proposes is that there can be prolonged periods of inertia and then a period of hectic activity and the latter occurs when there is a realisation of the time left to accomplish the job. One can perceive it as a compressing of various stages of the five stage model i.e., combining the forming and norming stages, then goes through a period of low performing, followed by storming, then a period of high performance, and finally adjourning. It can also be perceived as an iterative process between Phase II and III – conflict, action, conflict on a new issue and so on. The intense activity to overcome the time lost happens because of the feeling of collective fate. This intense activity punctuated by gaps creates equilibrium between work and lull. In fact, the lull period is often the time when the problems are incubated in the mind of its members leading to more creative solutions which are necessary. The period of intense activity is equally necessary to make the time lost in incubation.

Self Assessment Questions

4. The five stages in group formation are forming, _____, _____ and adjourning.
5. Punctuated equilibrium model explains a way to bring about balance between time lost in conflict and deadlines. (True/False)

11.5 Work Group Behaviour

We have seen the group process in detail. The task is impacted by group members, resources and group structure all of which is in the control of an organisation. This further impacts the group process and the performance. All work groups are part of larger systems and organisations and therefore cannot exist or work in isolation. It is therefore influenced by mainly external factors which include organisational strategy, authority structures, rules and regulations, access to resources, physical work conditions, organisational culture, performance systems, and reward structures. Work group behaviour model in figure 11.1 depicts how goals/tasks are achieved in a group context.

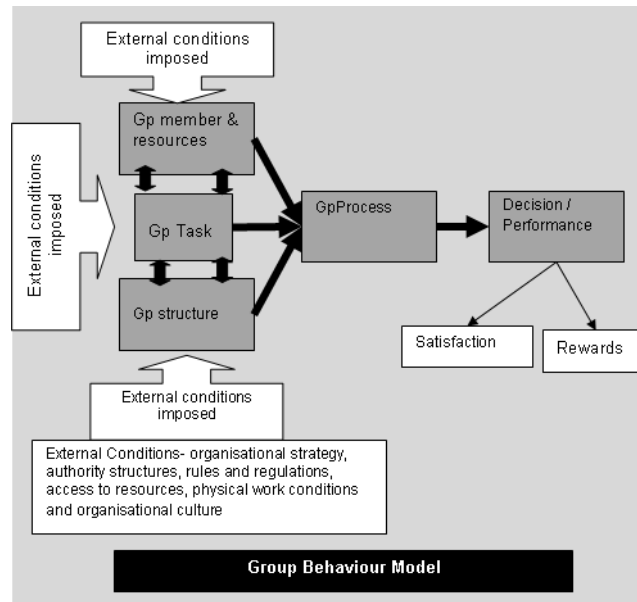


Fig. 11.1: Group Behaviour Model

What this model explains is that the task, resources allocated for it by the organisation including human capital and the structure of the group impacts the task, process and performance. For example, if the task is to create a modified product, the group membership with appropriate competencies has to be included in the team and a structure has to be created which might be matrix, wherein a member reports to the group as well as to the department head. The process of forming, storming, etc. therefore undergoes a modification, internal conflicts occur and is good to generate ideas and

options which might show intense activity and long lulls. The nature of process would lead to performance e.g., a creative solution v/s a mundane one which in turn affect reward and satisfaction. Thus, for example a very systematic and peaceful group process may mar the performance as it does not bring out contending views. This happens because the members selected were conformists and so on. There are external factors which affect this which are depicted in figure 11.1 and explained below:

- The strategy will influence the power of various work groups e.g., if we are on expansion, then the power of work groups to create new product is higher than when we were consolidating. This determines the resource allocation. Money, time, raw materials, and equipment which are allocated to the group by the organisation have a large bearing on the group's behaviour.
- Organisations have authority structures that define who reports to whom, who makes decisions, and what decisions individuals or groups are empowered to make.
- Organisations create rules, procedures, policies, job descriptions, and other forms of formal regulations to standardise employee behaviour.
- The more formal regulations that the organisation imposes on all its employees, the more the behaviour of work group members will be consistent and predictable and this will also lead to conformity.
- Group members' behaviour is influenced by how the organisation evaluates performance and what behaviours are rewarded.
- Every organization has an unwritten culture that defines standards of acceptable and unacceptable behaviour for employees. Members of work groups have to accept the standards implied in the organisation's dominant culture if they are to remain in good standing.
- The physical work setting creates both barriers and opportunities for work group interaction.
- **Group member:** The group member is perhaps one of the most important resources in a group. The member brings competencies (*knowledge, skills, and attitudes*) which play an important role in performance. Interpersonal skill or conflict resolution for example may not be a difficult skill but is important for group performance, though it may not have been in an individual task. Research also suggests that personality has an impact on the group performance. Attributes that

have a positive connotation in our culture tend to be positively related to group productivity, morale, and cohesiveness. These include sociability, initiative, openness, and flexibility. Negatively evaluated characteristics such as authoritarianism, dominance, and unconventionality tend to be negatively related to the dependent variables.

- **Group structure:** Work groups need structure for effective functioning. This depends on:
 - **Formal leadership:** The role of the leader is direction setting, creating alignment and creating engagement in the group. We will discuss these three in more detail under the unit on leadership. Direction setting is self explanatory. Creating alignment means aligning the people and their personal goals to the direction and cohesion and engagement means creating the leader-member dynamics which leads to trust and followership. The leader is thus able to do what the members could not do individually.
 - **Roles:** A role is a set of norms or expectations applied to the position by the role incumbent and the various others to whom the role matters. Each member has a role which develops through definition of it and acceptance of the same by the member. It develops through a combination of individual and group process i.e., the group members have an expected role for each individual and the individual too has own expectation. These are based on the perception of the members and the individual. Depending on the perception, the roles are accepted or rejected willingly or unwillingly. For example, a member of a group from the finance department expects to do the financial planning and others also expects him to do so thereby creating congruence; but if he is given the role of coordinator, he may not expect to do so and therefore a conflict (role conflict) arise. It can also occur when two roles are in conflict. Now it may be possible that we give him both these jobs in which case he may be short of time and therefore will feel a role overload, which reduces performance. Often groups are marred by role ambiguity e.g., a finance person given coordination role in a product development. He may lack information or understanding. It may exist in relation to activities, responsibilities, personal, and norms leading to poor performance.

Group process: We have already seen the group process in detail. It suffices to say that group process impacts a group task and it is not sufficient to create a good group structure, select members and provide resources if a task is to be executed well. The group process is also very important.

Self Assessment Questions

6. For a formal work group to be effective, it must be independent. (True/false)
7. Members of work groups have to accept the standards implied in the organisation's _____ culture if they are to remain in good standing.
8. When a person from a function role such as accounting or auditing role is included in a group task in which such role is not predominant, there is a danger of role _____.

11.6 Factors that Affect Group Behavior

There are several factors that affect group behaviour in addition to the group process. These factors affect the group process and group decision making and hence it is important to learn about them.

Norms

Norms can be defined as “acceptable standards of behaviour that are shared by the group members.” This is a guideline for members detailing what they ought and ought not to do under certain circumstances. Norms can be classified into many categories. Out of these, performance norms which gives guidelines on how hard they should work, how to get the job done, their level of output, appropriate levels of tardiness, etc. and allocation of resources norms can originate in the group or in the organisation are critical for group process. Other norms are appearance norms and social arrangement norms.

Conformity

Conformity is the process of adhering to group norms. Research evidence suggests strong evidence that groups can place strong pressures on individual members to change their attitudes and behaviours to conform to the group's standard. Norms are enforced effectively by the groups by:

- 1) Increasing communication with a non-conforming member
- 2) Ignoring the non-conforming member
- 3) Excluding him or her from activities and physical coercion or expulsion

Status

Status is a socially defined position or rank given to groups or group members by others. Those members of the group who enjoy a higher status are able to break group norms e.g., landing up late for meetings and often this can be a drag on the morale of the group.

Groupthink

Groupthink is perhaps the greatest danger to effectiveness of groups. Caught between the need for cohesion and multiplicity of ideas, most groups suffer from this. According to Irving Janis (1972), groupthink is "a deterioration of mental efficiency, reality testing, and moral judgment resulting from in-group pressures". Thus, the overemphasis on consensus and agreement leads members to be unwilling to evaluate group members' ideas critically. This hinders quality in decision-making and becomes an obstacle to group productivity. Highly cohesive groups tend to avoid conflicts and to demand conformity and defeat the purpose of groupthink.

Those groups with directive leadership, high stress, well insulate from external realities and those that lack systematic procedures for developing and evaluating alternatives in decision making tend to suffer from groupthink.

There are clear indicators of groupthink. These are:

1. Illusions of invulnerability where group members feel they are above criticism. This symptom leads to excessive optimism and risk taking or a suboptimal decision and refusal to change.
2. Illusions of group morality where the group members feel they are moral in their actions and therefore above reproach. This symptom leads the group to ignore the ethical implications of their decisions.
3. Illusions of unanimity because of which group members believe there is unanimous agreement on the decisions. Silence is misconstrued as consent.
4. Rationalisation whereby group members concoct explanations for their decisions to make them appear rational and correct resulting in other

alternatives being excluded from consideration and there is an unwillingness to reconsider the group's assumptions.

5. Stereotyping the enemy where those who oppose are stereotyped as evil or stupid. This leads the group to underestimate its opposition.
6. Self-censorship because of which members do not express their doubts or concerns about the course of action. This prevents critical analysis of the decisions.
7. Peer pressure by which any member who expresses doubts or concerns is pressured by other group members to accept the decision.
8. Mind guards by which some members take it upon themselves to protect the group from negative feedback. Group members are thus shielded from information that might lead them to question their action.

It is absolutely essential to prevent groupthink lest the very purpose of group gets defeated. To do this, you can make a group member assume the role of a critical evaluator. By actively voicing objections or doubts, the leader can avoid stating his or her position on the issue prior to the group decision, create several groups that work on the decision simultaneously, bring in outside experts to evaluate the group process, appoint a devil's advocate to question the group's course of action consistently, evaluate the competition carefully, posing as many different motivations and intentions as possible and once consensus is reached, and encourage the group to rethink its position by re-examining the alternatives.

Groupshift: This is a special case of groupthink. As the discussion proceeds, those who are more conservative, tend to shift to greater risk. This can happen because:

1. once the members become familiar, they become bolder
2. the society values more risk and therefore people want to be seen as more risk taking
3. group decision is not attributable to a single person, people take greater risk since they do not have to shoulder accountability for it singly

Social loafing

Social loafing occurs when one or more group members rely on the efforts of other group members and fail to contribute their own time, effort, thoughts or other resources to a group since it is harder to attribute the group's output to individual contributions. This is a drag on the group process and to

obviate it, it is important to have identifiable individual contributions to the group product, member self-evaluation systems etc. This is also perhaps the reason why group performance assessment and group reward, though considered the most reliable is seldom a success unless there is a component to assess and reward individual contribution.

Production blocking

Production blocking is limiting another person's output by getting in his or her way. Production blocking occurs when too many employees are trying to work in a given space or when the organisation has poorly planned the use of its facilities. It can also occur when the organisation assigns more than the optimal number of employees to carry out a task. This is often a problem on the shop floor in India.

Group decision making techniques

There are several ways to make group decisions. Some of these are outlined below:

- **Interacting:** Here, the members discuss an issue. The points and views go up and down; positions change often slowly, concerns are expressed and conflict is encouraged and later converged into a far better decision or action. This is perhaps the best way to take decision in a group. However, it is difficult and the leadership matters.
- **Brainstorming:** This is an idea generation exercise used when the problem is difficult and alternatives are not forthcoming. In order to generate ideas in a non-threatening environment, the problem is highlighted and ideas are recorded. No discussion is permitted as the purpose is to generate as many ideas as possible. Since there is no discussion, the member does not know the view of those other than the one who has given the idea and therefore, there is no group shift or groupthink at this stage. Once a large number of ideas are generated, they are evaluated one by one.
- **Nominal group technique:** This is a modified version of brainstorming. Here, the members write down their idea and pass it to the coordinator. Thus, the idea generation is done concurrently and obviates follow through with the idea of the boss which happens in a brainstorming where everyone is giving ideas one after the other. The basket of ideas is then clarified, and then each one silently ranks the ideas. The idea

with the highest ranking is considered though one can discuss the other ideas too. This gives a neat framework for the silent and shy members of the group to participate in the decision.

- **Electronic meeting:** Here, the members sit in the meeting room on computers and give their opinion through the system. This can be an online also. The authorship of the idea is kept anonymous and hence brutally frank ideas come out. It is also a fast way to do the meeting.

Self Assessment Questions

9. Norms are enforced effectively by the groups by 1) increasing communication with a non-conforming member, 2) ignoring the non-conforming member and 3) excluding him/ her from_____and_____.
10. Groupthink is a deterioration of mental efficiency, reality testing, and _____resulting from in-group pressures.
11. Devil's advocate is useful for preventing_____.
12. Three people in a group were very conservative in the first two meetings. Then they joined the others who supported a high risk decision. The reason for this can be explained by a phenomenon called_____.

11.7 Implications of Group Process for Organisations

Group process enables excellent planning since the views of several stake holders are taken into consideration. Thereafter, it gives excellent input for decision making.

The decisions are followed through more effectively since the groups participate in the decisions and take ownership for it. The buy in of the decision is far better in a group process.

It enables running the system with fewer controls because of the greater buy in and therefore is more cost effective.

The process identifies potential leaders and it becomes easier to have a succession planning or finding leaders for new operations.

It is an excellent motivating tool since there is a high degree of employee involvement in the process.

It gives meaning to the employees and other managers and therefore they feel less stressed because of a feeling of greater control. This in turn leads to higher productivity.

It enhances job satisfaction and therefore will impact retention and productivity.

If not orchestrated well, the process may be passed off as a sham and it can be counterproductive.

Self Assessment Questions

13. Group process enables in decreasing controls. (True/False)
14. Group process is an excellent motivating tool since there is a high degree of employee_____in the process.
15. Group process enhances job satisfaction and therefore impacts _____ and_____.

11.8 Summary

Let us recapitulate the important concepts discussed in this unit:

- A group is defined as two or more individuals who have regular contact and frequent interaction, mutual influence, common feeling of camaraderie and who work together to achieve a common set of goals.
- People join groups for goal achievement, identity, power and status, safety and security.
- In organisations groups may be formal or informal.
- Formal groups have defined goals, deadlines and roles. Some of the types of formal groups are command groups, task groups, committees.
- Informal groups are created due to proximity, social and emotional needs for bonding, common interests etc.
- Some of the types of informal groups are friendship groups, reference groups, membership groups, cliques.
- Stages of group formation are forming, storming, norming, performing and adjourning.
- Some of the factors affecting group behaviour are norms, conformity, status, groupthink, group shift, social loafing, production blocking.

- Some of the group decision making techniques are interacting, brainstorming, nominal group technique, electronic meetings.

11. 9 Glossary

- **Electronic meeting:** A version of brainstorming by which the members anonymously lodge their view or decisions using a computer. It is less time consuming and because of the anonymity, brings in frank views.
- **Norms:** Standards of behaviour, work, dress, etc. which a group decides to follow and its members ensure, but without any written rules and regulations. In simple words 'it is the way we do things here'.
- **Social loafing:** The tendency of some group members not to contribute to group work and depend on the work of others.
- **Groupshift:** A process that takes place in a group by which the members who were either conservative or risk taking shift to the other side. Usually it is seen that the more conservative individual decisions shift towards more risky group decisions.
- **Groupthink:** A process that takes place in a group by which the members decline to think independently and follow the members.

11.10 Terminal Questions

1. Explain the concept of a group.
2. What are the types of formal groups ?
3. What are the stages of group formation as proposed by Tuckman.
4. List the group decision making techniques.

11.11 Answers

Self Assessment Questions

1. Influence and goal
2. Synergy
3. False
4. Storming, performing
5. True
6. False
7. Dominant

8. Ambiguity
9. activities and physical coercion or expulsion
10. Moral judgment
11. Groupthink
12. Groupshift
13. True
14. Involvement
15. retention, productivity

Terminal Questions

- 1 A group consists of two or more individuals who are mutually influencing, working together for the attainment of common goals. Refer Section 11.3 for more details.
2. Formal groups may be command groups, task groups, committees. Refer Section 11.3 for more details.
3. The stages of group formation are forming, storming, norming, performing, adjourning. Refer Section 11.4 for more details.
4. Some of the group decision making techniques are interacting, brainstorming, nominal group technique, electronic meeting. Refer Section 11.6 for more details.

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